

Episode 121: Once Upon a Time... 69 – 1994 Part 3 – Celebration! Overseas!

The First Step

Tokyo is cold! It's April! What's with this cold weather!

Like most people, we've already washed and put away our winter down coats at home. But with this winter-wave coldness, should we respond with winter clothes? I thought about it, but no no, let's endure with spring layering! I'm being somewhat stubborn (laugh). I wonder how long this cold will continue?

Meanwhile, due to Iceland's volcanic eruption effects, European air travel seems to be in chaos. With flights getting cancelled across the board, my heart goes out to everyone whose travel plans got blown away.

Speaking of which, when my wife and I went to Greece for our honeymoon, our Athens flight from Santorini Island in the Aegean Sea was cancelled due to strong winds. Since we'd arranged the trip without going through agencies, we had to handle everything ourselves, and I remember struggling with airport counter staff in unfamiliar English. We hastily got ferry tickets and somehow made it to Athens.

Santorini Island's wharf battered by big waves, with waiting areas like refugee camps. It was packed with dejected tourists. Next to us a French couple was making phone calls frantically on their mobile. Apparently they couldn't make their Athens to Paris flight so were trying to change it, but that didn't work out either, and I vividly remember them getting into a subtle argument.

Both this Tokyo low temperature and Iceland's volcanic eruption are natural phenomena we can do nothing about. At times like this, ah, humans really are tiny, I think. But if humanity could control such nature, that would feel wrong somehow too.

Now then.

Dragon Ball Z Movie: The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy was completed by forcing through with strength at the end as usual. The latter half was indeed built through in-between animation and finishing orders to Korean and Chinese companies. So about half the total was painted with Taiyo Shikisai (太陽色彩) paints. I'd become quite skilled at Taiyo colour direction and retake handling.

However, Taiyo paints' weak colour reproduction remained problematic, and for colours too difficult to convert from STAC to Taiyo, rather than forcing conversion, I sent STAC paints to those companies and had them paint in STAC colours.

This considerably improved both screen quality and work efficiency, making me think "If needed, this whole approach could work for all Korean and Chinese orders."

During production of *The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy* in February, I received a certain directive from the company. It was a business trip to "EEI-TOEI" in Manila, Philippines.

EEI-TOEI ANIMATION CORPORATION—this was a joint venture between Toei Animation and Manila's local EEI Group, established to handle in-between animation and finishing work for Toei Animation productions. The remaining half of this *The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy* was worked on here.

Incidentally, as of 2010, EEI-TOEI has become a subsidiary of Toei Animation and is now "TOEI ANIMATION PHILIPPINES."

Senior staff had made several long-term business trips to this EEI-TOEI for technical guidance on actual work, but at this point when things had stabilised somewhat, the painting retake rate just wouldn't go down. So the trip's purpose was "inspection" and "actual work guidance" to investigate causes.

"Eh? Tsujita-kun, Manila is your first overseas?" laughed a certain interpreter from the overseas production team, somewhat amazed (wry laugh). Yes, this Manila trip was indeed my first overseas experience. Actually, I'd somehow obtained a passport when *Coo* ended, but this was truly the first time using that passport. While there were Japanese staff stationed locally, the trip there and back was basically solo travel.

As soon as *The Galaxy at the Brink! The Super Incredible Guy* was completed, preparation for the business trip began. Since the stay was several days, no particular visa was needed. The interpreter gave me detailed lectures on airport procedures and such. I received an envelope with local living expenses and business trip allowances.

Furthermore, "Don't exchange money at the hotel! The rates are bad. Definitely do some at the airport, then you can do it at 'Shoe Mart' near the studio." Hm? "Shoe Mart"? What's that? There were many things I didn't understand, but "ask Soya-kun and Tachisen-kun when you get there."

Going and returning, luggage included not just personal items but aluminium trunks packed full with work cuts. Multiple ones. Besides work luggage, there were also large quantities of souvenirs for local and stationed staff. Carrying that massive luggage, at Manila airport I'd have to handle customs procedures and such. In English too. This was a bit nerve-wracking.

English from middle school through university—reading and writing were reasonably okay, but conversation was almost unknown territory. This was completely away territory, different from using broken English with foreigners in Japan. And the local accommodation was also a local hotel. Naturally Japanese seemed impossible there too. Ah, English. I should have studied more seriously.

Departure was March 14th. 5 AM from Oizumi Studio. With heavy luggage by taxi to Hakozaiki's TCAT. Transfer there to limousine bus to Narita Airport. JAL flight from Terminal 2.

Ah, first Narita Airport (laugh). Scenery I'd seen in TV dramas was there. And me getting flustered (laugh). I somehow managed safe check-in. Passed immigration and became an airborne person. Then takeoff.

After a flight of just under five hours, I arrived in Manila. Getting off the plane, completing various procedures, collecting checked luggage and loading it on a cart to move. Passing between security guards equipped with automatic rifles, proceeding through long underground passages. Then outside to the lobby.

Whoosh! Tropical heat, crowds of Manila people with different skin colours, mysterious languages flying about. "Ah, foreign country!" I was overwhelmed and held my breath at that scene.

(10.04.16)